Qualitative Data Analysis and Reporting

What are we looking at? What can we claim? How do we show the path from data to interpretation?

Learning aims

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

01 Distinguish an excerpt, code, category, topic and theme, and explain how they relate.

02 Compare inductive, deductive and abductive reasoning in qualitative analysis.

03 Explain thematic analysis and its varieties, and compare them with content, narrative, discourse, critical discourse and grounded theory analysis.

04 Select an analysis method suited to a research question and justify your choice.

05 Code interview extracts, develop an interpretation supported by evidence and describe the analytic process.

Five terms that do different work

Shared working text · fictional teacher accounts (T1–T3)

Research question: How do teachers build confidence when trying a new feedback tool?

T1

“The workshop showed the buttons, but I did not try it until Mei sat beside me and showed me her class example.”

T2

“I watched the recording twice. I still asked a colleague whether my feedback sounded right.”

T3

“The training gave me a usable routine. I tried it that afternoon and adjusted it after students responded.”

Read T1–T3, then open the cards. Every example comes from this text. Compare the roles of original words, analytic labels and interpretations.

▼ Data excerpt

The participant’s or document’s words selected for analysis; keep their context and source ID.

Text example: “I still asked a colleague whether my feedback sounded right.”

These are T2’s exact words, selected from the full account above.

▼ Code

A concise analytic label attached to a meaningful segment.

Text example: Seeking peer reassurance

This label interprets T2’s action of asking whether the feedback sounded right.

▼ Category

A grouping of related codes used to organise material.

Text example: Sources of support

Groups learning through peer modelling (T1), seeking peer reassurance (T2) and using a training routine (T3).

▼ Topic

The subject the material discusses; it can serve as a descriptive heading.

Text example: Teacher training

Names the subject discussed through the workshop (T1), recording (T2) and training routine (T3).

▼ Theme

In interpretive thematic analysis, a patterned meaning organised around a central idea that answers the research question.

Text example: When formal guidance leaves uncertainty, teachers turn to peers to make the tool usable.

A provisional interpretation of T1 and T2. T3 shows that training can also support use directly; explore the pattern and its limits with fuller data.

> Which codes are grouped under “Sources of support”? What does the provisional theme interpret in T1 and T2? How does T3 help define its scope?

Match the analytic role

▼ **Revisit the shared working text T1–T3**

Shared working text · fictional teacher accounts (T1–T3)

Research question: How do teachers build confidence when trying a new feedback tool?

T1	T2	T3
“The workshop showed the buttons, but I did not try it until Mei sat beside me and showed me her class example.”	“I watched the recording twice. I still asked a colleague whether my feedback sounded right.”	“The training gave me a usable routine. I tried it that afternoon and adjusted it after students responded.”

Each item comes from the analysis of the same text on the previous page. Match its role in this example, check your choices and identify the supporting words in the accounts.

Teacher training	Your choice: _____
Seeking peer reassurance	Your choice: _____
“I still asked a colleague whether my feedback sounded right.”	Your choice: _____
When formal guidance leaves uncertainty, teachers turn to peers to make the tool usable.	Your choice: _____
Sources of support	Your choice: _____

▼ **Trace the matches to the text**

Topic: Names the subject discussed through the workshop (T1), recording (T2) and training routine (T3).

Code: This label interprets T2’s action of asking whether the feedback sounded right.

Data excerpt: These are T2’s exact words, selected from the full account above.

Theme: A provisional interpretation of T1 and T2. T3 shows that training can also support use directly; explore the pattern and its limits with fuller data.

Category: Groups learning through peer modelling (T1), seeking peer reassurance (T2) and using a training routine (T3).

Which item preserves original wording? Which items were constructed by the analyst? How would you examine the provisional theme with more interviews?

Where do codes and explanations come from?

Discuss each question before opening the explanation. These logics can inform different qualitative methods.

Inductive · build codes from the data

Data → codes → patterns

What actions or meanings would you label before choosing a theory?

▼ **Compare the logic**

Read closely and create provisional labels for relevant meanings. Compare segments and refine the labels as you examine more material.

Check: Which words support each code? What assumptions shape what you notice?

Deductive · apply a starting framework

Concepts → code definitions → data

What concepts would you define before coding, and what evidence would count for each?

▼ **Compare the logic**

Begin with codes informed by theory, prior research or the research question. Define their boundaries and examine which segments fit. Record material that the framework leaves unexplained.

Check: Can you justify the framework? Have you forced a passage into a code?

Abductive · explain a surprising finding

Puzzle ↔ possible explanations ↔ further evidence

What surprises you? Which competing explanations could account for it?

▼ **Compare the logic**

Move between observations and theoretical ideas to propose a plausible explanation. Compare alternatives and seek evidence that could strengthen, revise or challenge it.

Check: What evidence could separate the alternatives? Keep the explanation provisional.

Hybrid coding combines data-led and prior-concept codes. Abductive reasoning also identifies a puzzle, compares possible explanations and seeks further evidence.

Coding approaches reference ↗ · Timmermans & Tavory (2012) ↗

Three teachers, one question

Question: How do teachers build confidence when trying a new feedback tool?

T1

“The workshop showed the buttons, but I did not try it until Mei sat beside me and showed me her class example.”

T2

“I watched the recording twice. I still asked a colleague whether my feedback sounded right.”

T3

“The training gave me a usable routine. I tried it that afternoon and adjusted it after students responded.”

What is similar? What differs? Which account challenges an easy claim that peer support is always necessary?

Which code earns its place?

For T1’s “Mei sat beside me and showed me her class example”, choose a code that stays close to the action yet contributes to the question.

- **Technology**
- **Learning through peer modelling**
- **Teachers always need colleagues**

A topic names the area. A theme says something about it.

TOPIC HEADING

Teacher training

Tells us what the material concerns.

CANDIDATE INTERPRETIVE THEME

Confidence depends on usable guidance, whether formal or peer-led.

Connects T1–T3 around a central idea while leaving room for different routes.

Which further evidence would most strengthen the candidate theme?

- The number of times “training” appears
- More accounts showing how guidance was used and when it was insufficient
- A quotation from T1 repeated three times

▼ What makes a good theme?

A good theme is data-relevant, clearly defined, meaningful, consistent, and actionable. It captures patterns supported by multiple examples, maintains distinct boundaries from other themes, and reveals insight beyond surface observations.

Keep each inference inspectable

Source excerpt
T1, T2, T3

Meaningful segments
What is happening?

Initial codes
Short labels

Categories or patterns
Compare cases

Candidate theme / account
What does it mean?

Finding
Claim + evidence + limits

Use this evidence trail to connect your interpretations to the data. Adapt the analytic steps to your chosen method. Reflexive thematic analysis is recursive; grounded theory analysis, narrative analysis and discourse analysis make different analytic moves.

Explore qualitative analysis methods

Choose a method. Read its research situation and use the guiding questions to explore its purpose, procedure and findings, with AI if helpful. Then reveal the core features to check your understanding. Compare what each method attends to, how it analyses the material and what it produces.

Your question and intended finding

Choose a branch and explore further

Meaning and categories

Thematic analysis
Interpret patterns of meaning

Content analysis
Classify content and examine frequency

Stories and telling

Narrative analysis
Explore how stories are told

Language and power

Discourse analysis
Examine language in social action

Critical discourse analysis
Examine discourse, power and inequality

Processes and theory

Grounded theory analysis
Develop an explanation of a process

Which method fits the question?

Match the six questions to the six methods. Use each method once. Explain why the method fits the question before checking your answers.

Case 1	How do teachers use hedges, pronouns and turn-taking in feedback meetings to present expertise and negotiate agreement?	Your choice: _____
Case 2	How does admission-policy language legitimise unequal access for migrant pupils? Connect textual choices to institutional inequality.	Your choice: _____
Case 3	How do new teachers learn to negotiate assessment expectations? Use iterative interviews, comparisons and theoretically guided sampling to build a process theory.	Your choice: _____

Choose one question and explain why the selected method fits its intended finding. Rewrite the question so that a different method would fit better.

Which method fits the question?

Match the six questions to the six methods. Use each method once. Explain why the method fits the question before checking your answers.

Case 4	How does a teacher tell the story of moving from industry into teaching? Preserve the sequence, turning points and narrative voice.	Your choice: _____
Case 5	What shared meanings underpin teachers' confidence in giving feedback? Interpret patterns across interviews around central organising ideas.	Your choice: _____
Case 6	What kinds of feedback do teachers describe in 30 interviews? Define categories for feedback purposes and apply clear inclusion rules.	Your choice: _____

Choose one question and explain why the selected method fits its intended finding. Rewrite the question so that a different method would fit better.

Three readings of one excerpt

Read T1 again. Select a lens and predict what the analyst would look for.

> **T1 · “The workshop showed the buttons, but I did not try it until Mei sat beside me and showed me her class example.”**

Thematic | **Content** | **Discourse**

How does peer demonstration contribute to confidence across T1–T3?

Which lens best fits the original research question? What new question would make another lens preferable?

Final practice: read and code the interview

Classroom question: How did working at home during the pandemic reshape everyday working life?

> **Interviewer:** Can you tell me about your experiences with remote work during the COVID-19 pandemic?
>
> **Participant:**
>
> Sure. So, when the pandemic hit, our company quickly transitioned to remote work, and it was quite a significant shift for me. At first, I was excited about the idea of working from home, but it quickly became challenging. One of the biggest issues I faced was the lack of separation between work and personal life. When I was in the office, I had a clear boundary between work and home, but now that I was working from home, it felt like I was always on the clock. It was hard to disconnect and relax.
>
> Additionally, I found communication to be much more difficult. In the office, I could easily walk over to a coworker's desk to ask a question or have a quick chat, but with everyone working remotely, it was harder to get timely responses. Meetings also became a lot less productive. Without the face-to-face interaction, it was challenging to gauge people's reactions and keep everyone engaged.
>
> Another issue was the lack of social interaction. I missed the casual conversations and camaraderie that came with being in the office. It felt isolating at times, especially since I live alone. Overall, while there were some benefits to remote work, such as the flexibility and lack of commute, I found it to be a challenging adjustment.

Final practice: read and code the interview

Classroom question: How did working at home during the pandemic reshape everyday working life?

> Mark each meaningful phrase or sentence. Which label stays close to the material? Where might a segment need more than one code? Keep the full account as context.

One passage, three analytic routes

Do your codes begin with the text or prior concepts? What puzzle arises when flexibility and difficulty stopping work coexist?

▼ 1 · Compare inductive and deductive coding

The deductive column uses an instructor-defined work-life framework set before this demonstration; each cell defines the code's scope. Both columns illustrate analysis of the interview.

Interview phrase	Inductive: text-led label	Deductive: starting code and definition
"it felt like I was always on the clock"	Difficulty ending work	Time boundaries: separation of work and personal time
"it was harder to get timely responses"	Waiting for colleague responses	Coordination: getting information to work together
"it was challenging to gauge people's reactions and keep everyone engaged"	Losing interaction cues	Coordination: sustaining interaction during joint work
"It felt isolating at times, especially since I live alone."	Missing informal company	Social connection: everyday contact and belonging
"the flexibility and lack of commute"	Valuing flexibility and saved travel	Working conditions: practical benefits and constraints

Teaching extensions: the deductive framework and abductive explanations are added for this lesson. Abductive reasoning: Timmermans & Tavory (2012) ↗

One passage, three analytic routes

Do your codes begin with the text or prior concepts? What puzzle arises when flexibility and difficulty stopping work coexist?

▼ 2 · Abduction: explain the puzzle and compare alternatives

Puzzle: The participant values “the flexibility and lack of commute” while feeling “always on the clock”.

Possible explanation: Control over work location may differ from control over when work ends.

Alternative: The difficulty may reflect temporary pandemic arrangements or organisational expectations about responding.

Next evidence: Compare accounts with different working-hour expectations and at different times; seek material that distinguishes the explanations.

Teaching extensions: the deductive framework and abductive explanations are added for this lesson. Abductive reasoning: Timmermans & Tavory (2012) ↗

From initial codes to an analytic account

Practise Braun and Clarke's six phases with the remote-work interview. Discuss each question, then reveal the lesson illustration. Revisit earlier phases as your interpretation develops.

1 · Familiarise

What tensions do you notice before coding?

▼ **Compare the lesson illustration**

Memo: convenience sits alongside difficulty stopping work and reduced everyday contact. Re-read the full source before interpreting isolated lines.

2 · Generate initial codes

Which phrase or sentence supports your label?

▼ **Compare the lesson illustration**

Use the participant's phrases and sentences to justify provisional codes. The preceding table shows one inductive pass. Revisit boundaries and allow several relevant codes on a segment.

3 · Develop candidate themes

What central meaning could connect the codes?

▼ **Compare the lesson illustration**

Flexibility + feeling always on the clock → candidate idea: freedom over workplace can coexist with difficulty ending work. Delayed replies + lost interaction cues + isolation → candidate idea: everyday connection requires more deliberate effort.

One interview supports practice in coding and interpretation. Dataset-wide themes require fuller evidence; the ideas and paragraph here remain provisional teaching illustrations.

Elizabeth Yardley · six-phase guide ↗ · Braun & Clarke (2006) ↗

From initial codes to an analytic account

Practise Braun and Clarke's six phases with the remote-work interview. Discuss each question, then reveal the lesson illustration. Revisit earlier phases as your interpretation develops.

4 · Review and develop

Where does the candidate idea fit, and where might it fail?

▼ **Compare the lesson illustration**

Return to every segment and the fuller dataset. Compare people whose boundaries improved or who welcomed reduced contact. Keep benefits and difficulties visible; revise or split the ideas.

5 · Define and name

What does the theme explain beyond naming a topic?

▼ **Compare the lesson illustration**

Possible name: "A flexible workplace with an unfinished working day". Define its focus on the relation between spatial flexibility and stopping work. Treat this as a candidate requiring broader evidence.

6 · Write the analytic account

Can a reader trace your interpretation to the text?

▼ **Compare the lesson illustration**

Illustrative paragraph: The participant values "the flexibility and lack of commute" while feeling "always on the clock". A possible reading is that flexibility changes where work happens more readily than when it ends. Further accounts are needed to assess that interpretation.

One interview supports practice in coding and interpretation. Dataset-wide themes require fuller evidence; the ideas and paragraph here remain provisional teaching illustrations.

Elizabeth Yardley · six-phase guide ↗ · Braun & Clarke (2006) ↗

Coding terminology follows the method

Qualitative analysis has no universal requirement for “three-level coding”. The table compares coding phases within grounded theory traditions. Thematic, content, narrative and discourse analysis each have their own analytic procedures.

Grounded theory coding terminology: Chun Tie, Birks and Francis (2019), Table 1

Grounded theory tradition	Initial phase	Intermediate phase	Advanced phase
Traditional / classic	Open coding	Selective coding	Theoretical coding
Evolved (Strauss and Corbin)	Open coding	Axial coding	Selective coding
Constructivist (Charmaz)	Initial coding	Focused coding	Theoretical coding

▼ **Why do the names differ?**

History: authors and schools have developed distinct vocabularies and procedures.

Philosophical commitments: traditions differ in how they understand theory generation and the researcher’s role in constructing meaning.

Analytic tasks: labelling material, selecting significant codes, relating categories and integrating theory involve different work. Read each term alongside the procedure it names.

The columns help comparison; each term’s specific function still depends on the chosen tradition. Even a shared name can have different uses across traditions.

Coding phases, parent–child code hierarchies in software, and code–category–theme groupings describe different aspects of analysis. The six phases of thematic analysis do not imply six code levels. Report your method, define your terms and explain what you actually did.

Ask AI: “Illustrate focused and axial coding using the same interview extract. Explain each procedure’s purpose, tradition and methodological source.” Check its answer against the original methods texts.

Chun Tie, Birks & Francis (2019) · Table 1 ↗ · Braun & Clarke (2006) ↗

Make your analytic process transparent

1. Name the analytic approach and why it fits the question and data.
2. Describe the data, unit of analysis, analysts and their relevant positioning.
3. Explain the actual steps: coding or another procedure, comparison, revisions and exceptions.
4. Report how each finding is grounded in excerpts, context and a bounded claim.

> Use the target journal's instructions. APA JARS–Qual is a useful reporting prompt across qualitative traditions, not a replacement for method-specific reasoning.

APA JARS–Qual ↗

Take the lesson with you

Commonly used QDA software

NVivo, ATLAS.ti, MAXQDA, or other commercial qualitative data analysis (QDA) software.

Use these tools to organise materials, attach codes, retrieve coded extracts and write memos. Your analytic decisions and interpretations shape the findings.

Download the presentation, including the practice excerpts, guiding questions and method features.

Download lesson PDF **DEDC02 course materials →**

Thematic analysis

Explore the method through a research situation

> Learning scenario: A researcher interviews teachers about learning to use a new feedback tool, asking how support and confidence are experienced across their accounts.

Read the situation, then explore one question at a time. You can ask AI to teach you as a beginner, explain new terms and clearly label fictional examples.

What does thematic analysis help this researcher understand? What kinds of research questions suit this method?

Using three short fictional interview extracts, show how the researcher moves from reading the text to coding and developing a candidate theme. Explain each decision.

What would a thematic-analysis finding look like? Show how a theme explains something about teachers' experiences and how it differs from a topic heading such as "support".

Explain the method's purpose, steps and possible finding, then reveal the features below to check your understanding.

Thematic analysis

Core features

Develops patterns of meaning across a dataset in relation to a research question.
Themes organise an analytic account; their meaning and development depend on the chosen approach.
Reflexive, codebook and coding-reliability approaches use different researcher roles and quality criteria.

A family of approaches for developing themes across qualitative material in relation to a research question. Specify the approach and what a theme means within it.

Likely output: A thematic map and an analytic account supported by extracts.

▼ How do I do it?

Choose a thematic-analysis approach and state your analytic assumptions.

Work through the material, code relevant meanings and develop themes suited to that approach.

Explain each theme using extracts, interpretation and the scope of the claim.

Methods reference: Braun & Clarke · Understanding TA ↗

Thematic analysis · practice and output

▼ What can an output look like?

Classroom illustration: workload, peer support and professional fulfilment are starting topics. A candidate theme could explore how student progress makes demanding work feel worthwhile. Test that idea in a fuller dataset.

Practice-text illustration · candidate ideas to examine

Extract	Possible code	Candidate analytic idea
“feeling overwhelmed”	Managing accumulated demands	Demands compete with creative practice
“all worthwhile”	Finding value in student learning	Student progress helps sustain commitment

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

Methods reference: Braun & Clarke · Understanding TA ↗

Thematic analysis · 1 · Compare three families of thematic analysis

▼ 1 · Compare three families of thematic analysis

▼ Reflexive thematic analysis

Situated interpretation

Researchers develop meaning through sustained engagement and reflexivity. Coding evolves; themes are analytic constructions.

In practice: Use analytic memos and dialogue to deepen interpretations. Explain how your positioning shaped decisions.

Quality focus: Coherent interpretation, developed themes and traceable evidence. Agreement statistics have a different analytic rationale.

▼ Codebook thematic analysis

A structured coding framework

An explicit coding framework organises analysis, often in applied team research. Templates or matrices can support consistent working procedures.

In practice: Define and revise codes, retain contextual notes and document how team decisions develop. Document code definitions, examples and revisions.

Quality focus: A transparent framework and meaningful interpretation; explain how structure and revision serve the question.

▼ Coding-reliability thematic analysis

Reproducible coding decisions

A more standardised coding frame supports independent coders applying comparable rules. Reliability is part of the stated analytic logic.

In practice: Define code boundaries, train coders and explain how agreement and disagreements are assessed.

Quality focus: Clear operational decisions and justified reliability procedures, consistent with the underlying assumptions.

Choose an approach that fits the purpose, assumptions about knowledge and researcher role. Keep procedures and quality criteria coherent.

Braun & Clarke · Approaches and quality ↗

Thematic analysis · practice texts

▼ 2 · Explore analytic choices with the practice texts

Inductive/deductive concerns where concepts start; semantic/latent concerns the level of interpretation. These choices can combine within reflexive TA and should fit your view of knowledge.

Choose a practice text

Your choice: _____

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

> Many students reported feeling overwhelmed by the amount of coursework assigned during the semester. They expressed that while online resources were helpful, they often struggled to manage their time effectively. Some students mentioned that group projects added to their stress, as coordinating schedules with peers proved challenging. However, a few students noted that collaborating online allowed them to share ideas more freely, which enhanced their learning experience.

Both practice texts are included in full in this slide. The teacher text is first-person; the student text summarises several experiences. Preserve that distinction when analysing them.

Examine candidate ideas in a fuller corpus. These short passages support practice in coding and interpretation; a dataset-wide theme needs broader evidence.

Braun & Clarke · Analytic orientations ↗

Thematic analysis · explain analytic choices

▼ 2 · Explore analytic choices with the practice texts

Inductive/deductive concerns where concepts start; semantic/latent concerns the level of interpretation. These choices can combine within reflexive TA and should fit your view of knowledge.

Where do concepts start?

- Inductive · start with material
- Deductive · start with concepts

What level of meaning?

- Semantic · explicit meanings
- Latent · underlying assumptions

Teacher account · inductive · semantic

Examine candidate ideas in a fuller corpus. These short passages support practice in coding and interpretation; a dataset-wide theme needs broader evidence.

▼ Explain your judgement, then compare

“Workload” can name a topic; “feeling overwhelmed by administration” can be a code; “student progress makes demanding work worthwhile” proposes an interpretive idea to test. What material would support or revise it?

Braun & Clarke · Analytic orientations ↗

Thematic analysis · compare analytic choices

Possible codes: enjoying creative planning; feeling overwhelmed by marking and administration; wanting collegial resource-sharing; valuing student learning. These stay close to explicit expressions.

Possible interpretation: student progress helps make sustained pressure feel worthwhile. Examine the implied relationship between commitment and demands, and record what further evidence could challenge it.

Start with the analytic concepts demands, resources and fulfilment. Map grading to demands, desired collegial support to resources, and student learning to fulfilment. Record material that the starting frame misses.

Use those starting concepts to ask how meaningful rewards might legitimise heavy demands. Treat this as a tentative interpretation; “worthwhile” provides a starting clue, with context and alternative readings still to examine.

Possible codes: managing coursework load; struggling with time; coordinating peers’ schedules; sharing ideas online. The passage reports experiences collectively, so keep that source form visible.

Possible interpretation: collaboration creates both opportunities and coordination demands. The contrast within the passage suggests an idea to examine in richer student accounts.

Start with demands, resources and learning opportunities. Classify scheduling as a demand, online resources as support, and idea-sharing as an opportunity; retain the different reported responses.

Ask how digital collaboration redistributes the work of organising learning. The scheduling difficulty and freer idea-sharing support competing readings; neither establishes students’ hidden intentions.

Thematic analysis · 3 · Work through reflexive thematic analysis

▼ 3 · Work through reflexive thematic analysis

Move back and forth through these six phases as interpretations develop. Re-reading, revising codes and reshaping themes are part of the work.

▼ 1 Read and revisit

Read the full material, note context and initial questions.

What surprised me, and how did my assumptions shape what I noticed?

▼ 2 Code meaningful material

Label features relevant to the question; keep extracts and context together.

Which exact words support my code? What other code could be plausible?

▼ 3 Build candidate patterns

Explore relationships among codes and a possible organising idea.

What meaning connects these codes? Which data differ?

▼ 4 Challenge the patterns

Review candidate themes against extracts and the whole corpus; revise their boundaries.

Is this idea supported across the relevant material? Where does it fail?

▼ 5 Clarify the theme claim

Define the central idea, scope and relation to other themes.

What does this theme explain, and how would I name it precisely?

▼ 6 Present the interpretation

Weave extracts into an analytic account; relate it to the question and relevant literature.

Can a reader follow the evidence for this interpretation and its limits?

> In reflexive TA, examine how your positioning shapes interpretation and use analytic dialogue to deepen it. If your aim is to assess coder agreement, explain the analytic logic of your chosen approach.

Braun & Clarke · Six phases of reflexive TA ↗

Content analysis

Explore the method through a research situation

> Learning scenario: A researcher analyses 30 teacher interviews to identify the purposes of feedback they describe and how frequently each purpose is mentioned.

Read the situation, then explore one question at a time. You can ask AI to teach you as a beginner, explain new terms and clearly label fictional examples.

What does content analysis help this researcher understand? Explain what a category is and how categories can be developed from the text or prior concepts.

Using three fictional interview extracts, show how to choose a coding unit and define categories with inclusion rules and examples. Explain how to handle an extract that fits more than one category.

Show a clearly fictional category-and-frequency table. Explain the difference between counting mentions and counting teachers, how to calculate percentages, and what the counts can and cannot tell us about meaning or importance.

Explain the method’s purpose, steps and possible finding, then reveal the features below to check your understanding.

Content analysis

Core features

Uses an explicit category system to classify and interpret content.
Can report frequencies or percentages for a defined unit: words, coded segments, documents or participants.
Defines category boundaries and counting rules, then interprets distributions in context; frequency alone does not establish importance.

Systematic analysis of material through an explicit category system. Content analysis can interpret meanings and examine frequency: how often words or categories occur, or how many documents or participants mention them. Define the coding and counting units, state the denominator for percentages, and explain whether categories can overlap. Counts describe distribution; interpreting their meaning and importance requires context. Qualitative approaches can develop categories from the data, start from prior concepts, or interpret selected counts in context.

Likely output: A category table with definitions and source-linked examples; where appropriate, a frequency or percentage table and an interpretation of the distribution.

▼ How do I do it?

Define the research question, material, coding unit and counting unit.

Develop category definitions, inclusion rules and examples; pilot and revise them.

Classify the material. When frequency serves the question, count occurrences or cases using explicit rules and report the denominator for percentages.

Interpret category meanings, distributions, relationships and exceptions in context.

Methods reference: Krippendorff & Bock · The Content Analysis Reader ↗

Hsieh & Shannon (2005) · Qualitative approaches to content analysis ↗

Content analysis · practice and output

▼ Practice text for this lesson

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

Use this short account to practise analytic judgement. Other fictional material in the example tables is labelled separately.

▼ What can an output look like?

In the teacher practice text, “grading” and “administrative tasks” can enter a work-demands category. Define the category boundary and keep the sentence context.

Practice-text illustration · a small category system

Category	Inclusion rule	Practice-text example
Work demands	Tasks requiring time and effort	Grading; administrative tasks
Desired support	Requested assistance or sharing	Ideas and resources from colleagues
Sources of fulfilment	Experiences described as rewarding	Students engage and learn

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

Methods reference: Krippendorff & Bock · The Content Analysis Reader ↗

Hsieh & Shannon (2005) · Qualitative approaches to content analysis ↗

Narrative analysis

Explore the method through a research situation

> Learning scenario: A teacher tells the story of moving from industry into teaching, describing early expectations, difficulties and a turning point.

Read the situation, then explore one question at a time. You can ask AI to teach you as a beginner, explain new terms and clearly label fictional examples.

What does narrative analysis help us understand about this story and how the teacher tells it?

Using a short fictional account, show how a researcher examines the sequence of events, a turning point and how the teacher presents themselves.

What would a narrative-analysis finding look like? What understanding might be lost if the account were separated into unrelated topic codes?

Explain the method’s purpose, steps and possible finding, then reveal the features below to check your understanding.

Narrative analysis

Core features

Treats the story and its telling as an analytic focus.
Examines chronology, plot, turning points, voice and self-presentation in context.
Preserves connections within a narrated journey when developing an interpretation.

Analysis of stories as situated accounts: chronology, plot, turning points, voice and the circumstances of telling can shape meaning.

Likely output: A contextualised account or narrative reconstruction, supported by the teller's words.

▼ How do I do it?

Identify a story or narrative episode and preserve its surrounding context.

Examine sequence, characters, turning points and how the narrator presents events.

Interpret how the telling makes sense of experience; explain your chosen narrative approach.

Methods reference: Riessman · Narrative Methods ↗

Narrative analysis · practice and output

▼ Practice text for this lesson

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

Use this short account to practise analytic judgement. Other fictional material in the example tables is labelled separately.

▼ What can an output look like?

The teacher practice paragraph is a short reflective account. A richer career story would be needed to explore transitions, turning points and changing identity in depth.

Fictional illustration · keep a story's sequence visible

Story movement	Narrated event	Possible meaning
Beginning	Leaves industry for teaching	Seeking purposeful work
Turning point	A first difficult lesson	Reconsidering competence
Later reflection	A colleague shares a strategy	Recasting help-seeking as learning

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

▼ Empirical study example

Karalis Noel (2021) · *Identity Tensions* ↗

Four interviews over a year underpin an account of one former teacher's schooling, preparation, work and departure. Notice how repeated interviews support attention to the sequence and telling of one person's story.

Using this study summary, explain how the material and analytic decisions fit the method. What further evidence would help you assess the interpretation?

Methods reference: Riessman · Narrative Methods ↗

Discourse analysis

Explore the method through a research situation

> Learning scenario: A fictional school policy states: “Teachers must check all AI-assisted work. Students must prove that submitted work is their own.” A researcher asks how this wording constructs teachers’ and students’ roles.

Read the situation, then explore one question at a time. You can ask AI to teach you as a beginner, explain new terms and clearly label fictional examples.

What does discourse analysis ask about this policy language? How does its focus differ from listing the topics mentioned?

Examine “must”, “check” and “prove”. What possible roles or relationships do these words construct? Explain the textual evidence for each interpretation.

What information about the policy’s audience, production and use would help assess those interpretations? Show what a cautious discourse-analysis finding might look like.

Explain the method’s purpose, steps and possible finding, then reveal the features below to check your understanding.

Discourse analysis

Core features

Examines language as social action and the construction of meanings and positions.
Analyses specific linguistic choices in their social or interactional context.
Builds an evidence-based account of what language does, using a stated discourse approach.

A family of approaches examining how language works in context to construct meanings, identities and social action. Specify the tradition and textual focus.

Likely output: An evidence-linked account of how particular linguistic choices accomplish social work.

▼ How do I do it?

Choose an approach and locate texts or interactions in their production and use contexts.

Closely examine wording, pronouns, categories, positioning and rhetorical choices.

Link textual observations to what language accomplishes in that setting.

Methods reference: Gee · Discourse analysis ↗

Discourse analysis · practice and output

▼ Practice text for this lesson

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

Use this short account to practise analytic judgement. Other fictional material in the example tables is labelled separately.

▼ What can an output look like?

The teacher's "I sometimes wish" makes a request indirectly; "all worthwhile" positions commitment. These are possible readings to examine in context.

Practice-text illustration · link words to a possible function

Wording	Textual observation	Possible social work
"I sometimes wish"	Tentative expression of need	Softening a request for support
"all worthwhile"	Positive evaluation after challenges	Presenting commitment despite pressure

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

▼ Empirical study example

Balán (2026) · critical discourse analysis · *The "skills-first" illusion* ↗

A critical discourse analysis of 15 Microsoft communications links textual choices to discourse and social context. The critical discourse analysis card explores this approach.

Using this study summary, explain how the material and analytic decisions fit the method. What further evidence would help you assess the interpretation?

Methods reference: Gee · Discourse analysis ↗

Critical discourse analysis

Explore the method through a research situation

> Learning scenario: A fictional school policy states: “Teachers must check all AI-assisted work. Students must prove that submitted work is their own.” A researcher examines how responsibilities, authority and opportunities to challenge decisions are distributed.

Read the situation, then explore one question at a time. You can ask AI to teach you as a beginner, explain new terms and clearly label fictional examples.

What additional questions about power and inequality would critical discourse analysis bring to this policy?

Which wording could support an interpretation about authority or responsibility? What alternative interpretation should the researcher consider?

What further evidence about school rules and actual practices would support a claim about inequality? Show how textual and contextual evidence could be connected in a finding.

Explain the method’s purpose, steps and possible finding, then reveal the features below to check your understanding.

Critical discourse analysis

Core features

Makes power, ideology and inequality explicit analytic concerns.
Connects close textual analysis with institutional and social relations.
Supports critical interpretations with both textual and contextual evidence.

A critical orientation within discourse research. It examines how text and discursive practices legitimise, reproduce or challenge unequal social relations.

Likely output: An argument linking specific textual evidence, discursive practices and social structures.

▼ How do I do it?

Identify the social problem, institutional context and critical framework.

Analyse textual choices and how texts are produced, circulated and taken up.

Connect the textual evidence to power and inequality; consider alternative interpretations.

Methods reference: Balán (2026) · empirical application of Fairclough's model ↗

Critical discourse analysis · practice and output

▼ Practice text for this lesson

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

Use this short account to practise analytic judgement. Other fictional material in the example tables is labelled separately.

▼ What can an output look like?

A fictional policy calling learners “future workforce assets” could position education around productivity. Examine who gains authority and which educational purposes are absent.

Fictional policy illustration · trace a critical argument

Wording	Representation	Critical question
“future workforce assets”	Learners framed as economic resources	Which educational purposes are privileged?
“every learner must remain competitive”	Obligation placed on individuals	How is responsibility distributed?

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

▼ Empirical study example

Balán (2026) · *The “skills-first” illusion* ↗

A corpus of 15 Microsoft AI-skilling communications is examined through Fairclough’s critical discourse approach, connecting textual choices with discourse and social context.

Using this study summary, explain how the material and analytic decisions fit the method. What further evidence would help you assess the interpretation?

Methods reference: Balán (2026) · empirical application of Fairclough’s model ↗

Grounded theory analysis

Explore the method through a research situation

> Learning scenario: A researcher wants to explain how novice teachers learn to manage difficulties with a new feedback tool. Interviews and analysis continue together as the study develops.

Read the situation, then explore one question at a time. You can ask AI to teach you as a beginner, explain new terms and clearly label fictional examples.

What does grounded theory analysis aim to produce? Why would the researcher continue collecting data while analysing earlier interviews?

Using a fictional teacher example, explain how comparing incidents, writing analytic notes and developing categories help the researcher understand the process.

Suppose an early idea is that teachers seek peer help when formal training proves insufficient. Whom should the researcher interview next, and why? Show how further evidence could change the developing explanation.

Explain the method’s purpose, steps and possible finding, then reveal the features below to check your understanding.

Grounded theory analysis

Core features

Develops an explanatory theory of a process through iterative analysis and data collection.
Uses constant comparison, analytic memos and theoretical sampling to develop categories and their relationships.
States the grounded-theory tradition and follows its analytic logic.

An analytic approach within grounded theory for developing explanatory categories and their relationships. Constant comparison, memo writing and theoretical sampling support theory development.

Likely output: A substantive theory or process model with evidence for relationships between categories.

▼ How do I do it?

Compare incidents and develop analytic codes while collecting data.

Write memos about categories, their properties and relationships; let these guide further sampling.

Integrate the categories into an explanatory theory and examine its adequacy.

Grounded-theory traditions use different coding language: constructivist work often uses initial and focused coding; Straussian work can use open, axial and selective coding. State the approach you follow.

Methods reference: Charmaz · Constructing Grounded Theory ↗

Grounded theory analysis · practice and output

▼ Practice text for this lesson

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

Use this short account to practise analytic judgement. Other fictional material in the example tables is labelled separately.

▼ What can an output look like?

The teacher practice text could suggest an initial question about sustaining commitment under workload pressure. A theory would require iterative data collection and comparison.

Fictional illustration · proposed relationships to test

Condition	Action / interaction	Proposed consequence
Work demands intensify	Seeking collegial support	Accessing workable routines
Usable guidance becomes available	Trying and adapting routines	Sustaining participation
Support remains inaccessible	Continuing alone	Prolonged strain

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

▼ Empirical study example

Brown, Howard & Walsh (2022) · *Building Trauma Informed Teachers* ↗

23 interviews and a theoretical-sampling focus group with seven interviewees. Notice that analysis informs further sampling, supporting category development and an explanatory theory.

Using this study summary, explain how the material and analytic decisions fit the method. What further evidence would help you assess the interpretation?

Methods reference: Charmaz · Constructing Grounded Theory ↗

Method selection · compare your reasoning

Case 1: Discourse analysis

Discourse analysis examines how language choices accomplish social actions in their interactional context.

Case 2: Critical discourse analysis

A critical approach within discourse analysis explicitly connects textual choices to power and institutional inequality.

Case 3: Grounded theory analysis

Grounded theory develops relationships between categories into an explanatory theory; ongoing analysis guides what data to seek next.

Method selection · compare your reasoning

Case 4: Narrative analysis

Narrative analysis examines how a story is organised and told over time. Isolating quotations into topics could lose its sequence and plot.

Case 5: Thematic analysis

Thematic analysis develops patterns of shared meaning around central organising ideas. A theme explains a pattern through a central organising idea.

Case 6: Content analysis

Content analysis builds and applies a category system to classify meaningful material, preserving definitions and context.